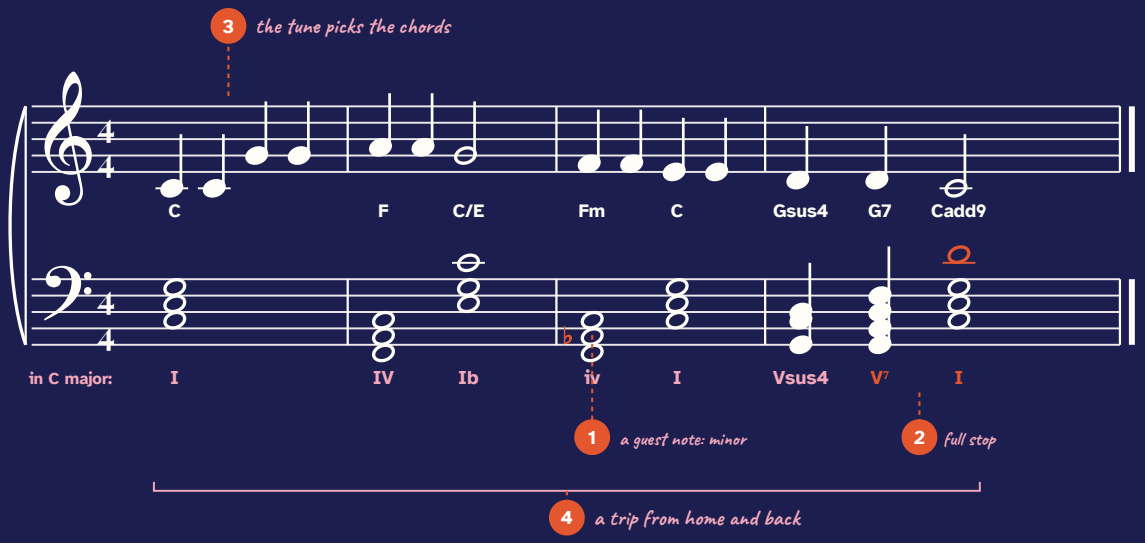
PART VI · PUT THEM TO WORK

Harmony in music

A melody is the singer; harmony is the band behind it. Here the chords start moving: guests from outside the key, endings, chords under a tune, and the trips every song takes. All of it is in the same four bars.



1 **Chords from outside the key** p. 136
a guest note: A♭ in C major

2 **Cadences** p. 139
V to I ends a phrase like a full stop

3 **Chords under a melody** p. 142
the tune's main notes pick the chord

4 **Progressions everywhere** p. 144
the same few trips, in every song

★ **Tips: when harmony goes wrong** p. 146

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1

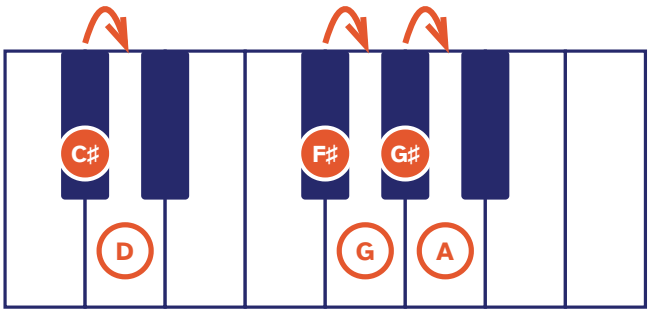
Chords from outside the key

In C major, home is the white keys, so a black key in a chord is a **guest**. Guests never stay: each one moves to the **very next key** (no key between), and shows you where the music goes next.

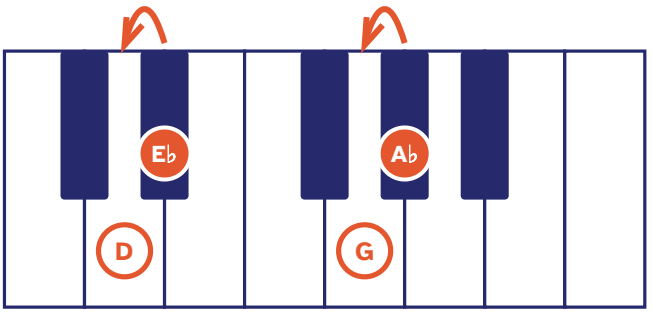
THE SECRET

Sharp guests push up, flat guests sigh down: follow them one key and you find the next chord.

Sharp guests push up

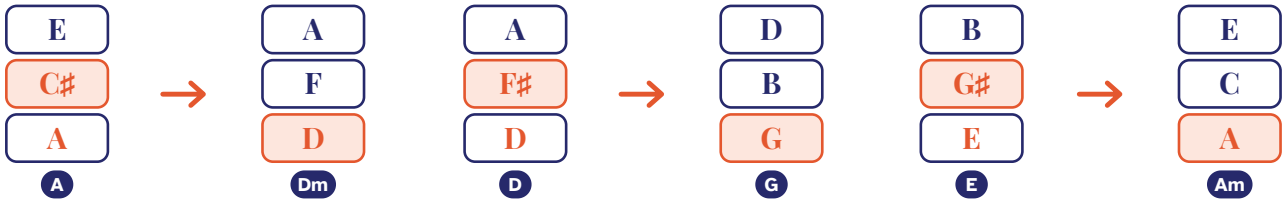


Flat guests sigh down

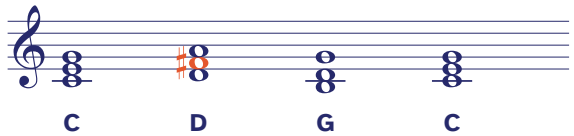


1. Find the **black key** in the chord: that is the guest.
2. A **sharp**? Go **up** to the very next key. A **flat**? Usually **down** to the very next key.
3. You have found a note of the **next chord**. Play it and hear it land.

Sharp guests: up one key names the next chord

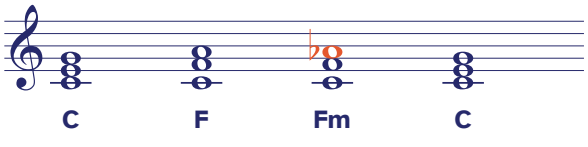


C♯ goes up to **D**, so the next chord is D minor. F♯ goes up to **G**: G. G♯ goes up to **A**: A minor.



Try it in a song: C, D, G, C. The **F♯** pushes up into G, then G leads home to C.

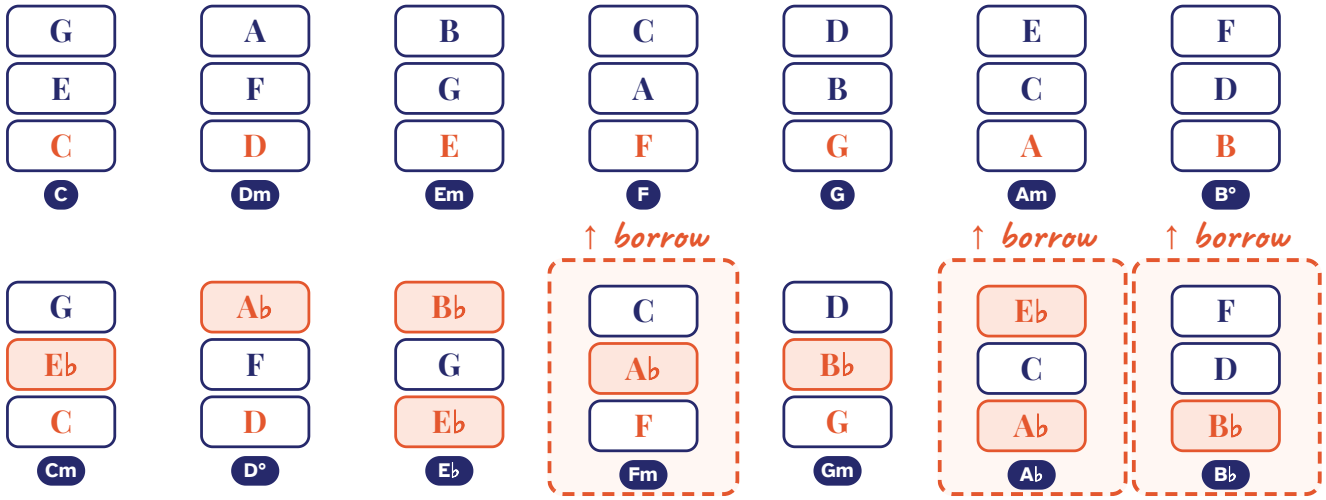
Flat guests: borrowed from the twin, they sigh down



C major and C minor are **twins** (the parallel minor): the same home note, C, in different clothes. A flat guest is one piece of the twin's outfit. In C, F, Fm, C the **A♭** sighs down to G.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1 · CONTINUED

C major *at home*



C minor *the twin: same home note, darker clothes*

Their names, for later

GUEST	NOTES	MOVES	NEXT CHORD	ITS NAME
sharp guest	D F♯ A	F♯ up to G	G	V of V
sharp guest	A C♯ E	C♯ up to D	Dm	V of ii
sharp guest	E G♯ B	G♯ up to A	Am	V of vi
flat guest	F A♭ C	A♭ down to G	C	borrowed iv
flat guest	A♭ C E♭	A♭ down to G	G or C	borrowed ♭VI
flat guest	B♭ D F	B♭ on to C	C	borrowed ♭VII

B♭ is the flat guest that walks **up** instead, on to C (one key between: a tone): the rock and film ending B♭ → C.

EXAMPLE

Where do the guests go? B D♯ F♯ in C major



1. **Find the black keys:** there are two guests here.
2. **Both are sharps:** move each up to the very next key. Where do they land?
3. **Which cake in C major** holds both landing notes?

D♯ goes up to E, F♯ up to G: both live in **E minor** (E G B). B D♯ F♯ leads to Em.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

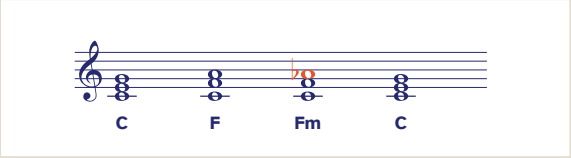
Where does the guest go?

1	2	3
E	E♭	A
C♯	C	F♯
A	A♭	D
A	A♭	D

In C major: find each guest, follow it one key, and write the chord that comes next.

Answer: 1 C♯ up to D: D minor · 2 A♭ down to G, E♭ down to D: G · 3 F♯ up to G: G.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C, F, Fm, C slowly.

Hear the A♭ sigh down to G? Now play C, D, G, C: the F♯ pushes up instead. One sighs, one pushes.

THINK OF IT A surprise guest at dinner: one new face changes the whole conversation, and then everyone goes home.

TRAP

- × Following a sharp downwards: sharps push **up**, flats usually sigh **down**.
- × Calling every black key a guest: in G major F♯ is at home. A guest is a note from outside the key you are in.
- × Learning the names first: play it, hear where the guest goes, then name it.
- × Mixing up the relatives: C minor is C major's twin (same home note). A minor is its neighbour (same key signature). We borrow from the twin.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Slash chords p. 131 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 17–18 · Online: Library › Chromatic chords

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2

Cadences

A phrase is a musical sentence, and it needs punctuation. The last two chords of a phrase are its **cadence**. They tell you: finished, taking a breath, or surprise!

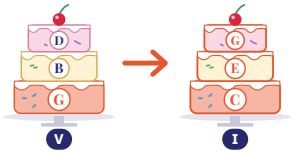
THE SECRET

Music has full stops and commas too: listen to the last two chords of a phrase.

.

Perfect

V → I

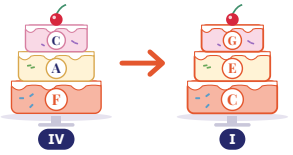


Home. The end.

Amen

Plagal

IV → I

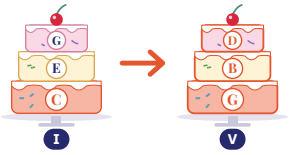


A soft, gentle end.

,

Imperfect

… → V

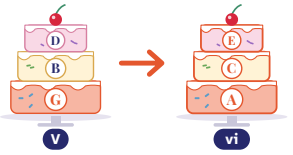


To be continued…

?!

Interrupted

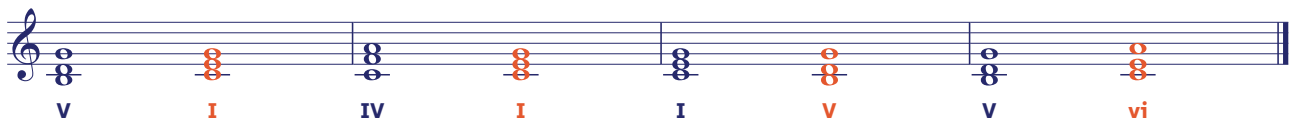
V → vi



Surprise! Not home.

1. Find the end of a phrase: often a long note, or a breath.
2. Name its **last two chords** with numerals: V I, IV I, anything then V, or V vi.
3. Match the punctuation: full stop (.), Amen, comma (,) or ?!

The four cadences in C

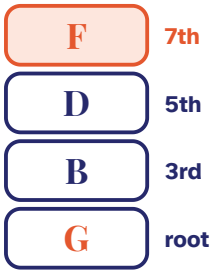


Perfect, plagal, imperfect, interrupted. The red chord is where each one lands.

CADENCE	CHORDS	FEELS LIKE	ALSO CALLED
Perfect	V → I	a full stop: finished	authentic, full close
Plagal	IV → I	the “A-men” sung at the end of a song in church	Amen cadence
Imperfect	any → V	a comma: waiting	half close, half cadence
Interrupted	V → vi	a surprise: not home yet	deceptive

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2 · CONTINUED

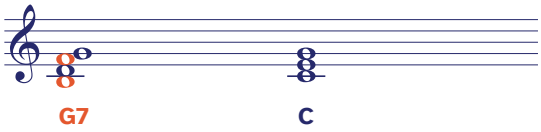
Why G7 pulls home



Add the 7th to V and the full stop gets stronger.

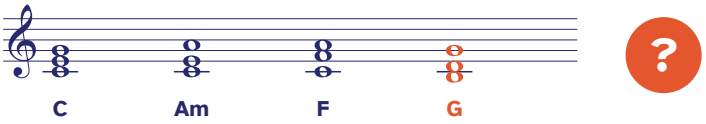
In **G7** two notes lean towards C major. The **B** rises to **C**, the **F** falls to **E**: each to the very next key, no key between. Two tiny steps, and you are home (Seventh chords, p. 122).

It works like a guest: B pushes up, F sighs down (p. 136).



EXAMPLE 1

How does this phrase end? C Am F G

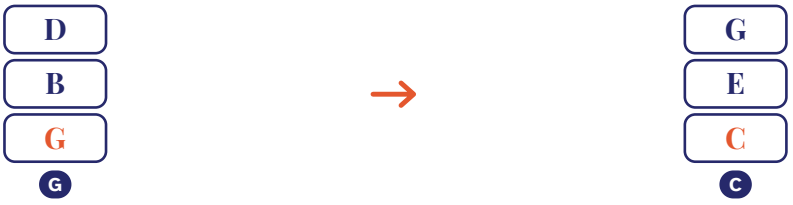


1. **Find the last two chords** of the phrase.
2. **Turn them into numerals** in C major.
3. **Which punctuation card** ends that way?

F then G is IV → V: it lands on V, the comma. An **imperfect cadence**.

EXAMPLE 2

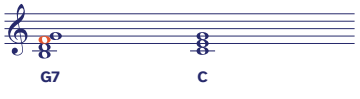
How does Twinkle end?



1. **The last two chords** of Twinkle in C are G, then C.
2. **Turn them into numerals.**
3. **Which card** goes from that chord to that chord?

V → I: a **perfect cadence**, the full stop. That is why Twinkle sounds finished.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play G7, then C. The end!

Now play G7, then A minor: “huh?!” That is the interrupted cadence. Then play F, then C, and sing “A-men”.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Surprise! G7, then A minor

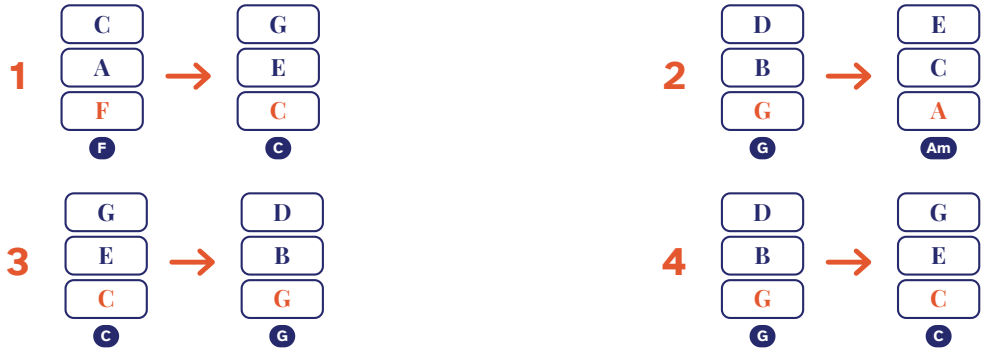


1. **G7 leans towards home**: you expect C.
2. **But the next chord is A minor.** Which numeral is it in C?
3. **V → that numeral:** which card?

V → vi: an **interrupted cadence**. The music was heading home, then turned the corner.

GAME

Punctuate the phrases



Each pair ends a phrase in C major. Turn the letters into numerals first (C is I, F is IV, G is V, Am is vi), then write full stop, comma, Amen or ?! beside each.

Answer: 1 Amen (plagal), 2 ?! (interrupted), 3 comma (imperfect), 4 full stop (perfect).

THINK OF IT Punctuation in a sentence: a full stop ends it, a comma makes you wait, and a surprise makes you gasp. Music ends its phrases the same way.

TRAP

- × Calling every ending on I (C) perfect: a perfect cadence comes **from V**. F to C is plagal.
- × Mixing up imperfect and perfect: imperfect **ends on** V; perfect **starts on** V and lands on I.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Seventh chords p. 122 · Chords under a melody p. 142

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 19–20 · Online: Library › Cadences

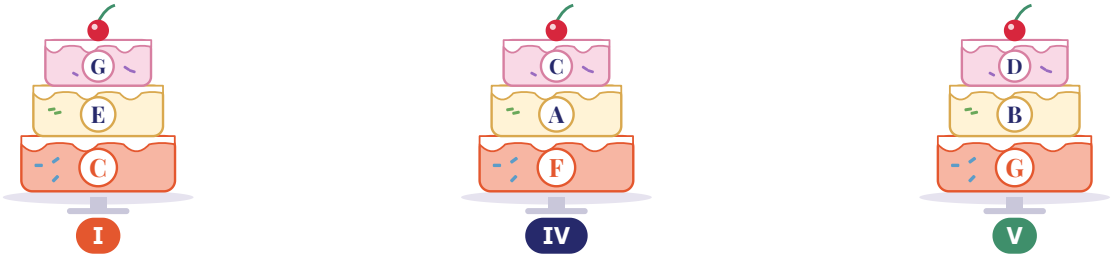
PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 3

Chords under a melody

The melody is the singer; the chords are the band. A good band plays chords that hold the singer's main notes.

THE SECRET

Look at the melody's main notes, then pick the cake that holds them.



C	D	E	F	G	A	B
I, IV	V	I	IV	I, V	IV	V

Which cake holds the tune's main notes?

Every note of C major lives in I, IV or V. C and G live in two: let your ear choose.
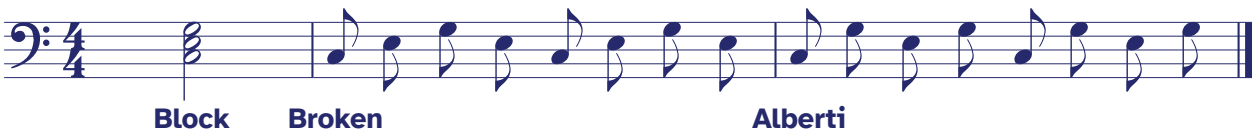
1. Look at the **main notes** of the bar: the long ones, and the ones on beats 1 and 3.
2. Find the cake that holds them: **I, IV or V**.
3. Play that chord in the left hand while the right hand plays the tune.

Twinkle, Twinkle, with its chords



C C G G sit in I (C); A A in IV (F), then G in I; F F in IV, E E in I; D D in V (G), and the last C in I. The chord changes halfway through bars 2, 3 and 4.

Three ways to play the chord in the left hand



Block: all three at once. Broken: one at a time, up and down. Alberti: low, high, middle, high, named after Domenico Alberti, who loved it.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Choose the chord: E D C D | E E E

E D C D | E E E

red = beats 1 and 3

1. **Bar 1:** which notes fall on beats 1 and 3 (red)?
2. **Which cake** holds both of them: I, IV or V?
3. **Bar 2:** E E E. Which cake holds E?

E and C both live in **I**, and so does E: both bars take **I** (C). That is the start of Mary Had a Little Lamb.

GAME

Pick the cake
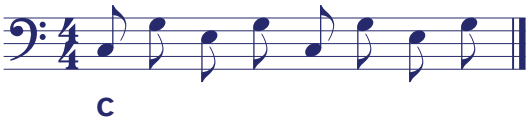
F A F A D B G B G E C E

1 2 3

Each bar is in C major. Which cake holds its notes: I, IV or V?

Answer: 1 IV (F A C) · 2 V (G B D) · 3 I (C E G).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Left hand: C G E G, over and over.

That is the Alberti bass on the C chord. Keep it going while you hum Twinkle, then try it on F (F C A C) and G (G D B D).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545: the left hand



The opening left hand is an **Alberti bass**: C G E G is just the C chord, broken into low, high, middle, high; D G F G is G7 (G B D F, without the B). Mozart wrote it an octave higher, starting on middle C.

Try it. Play this left hand alone, then add the famous tune: C, E G, B, C D C.

THINK OF IT Like picking a coat for the weather: when the tune changes, change the chord.

TRAP

- × Choosing a chord for a passing note: use the main notes (strong beats, long notes).
- × Playing the left hand louder than the tune: the melody is the star, the chords are the stage.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 21–22 · Online: Library › Chords

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 4

Progressions everywhere

A **progression** is a trip from chord to chord. A handful of trips turn up in song after song. Learn them by their numbers and you can play them in any key.

THE SECRET
Most songs take the same few trips: home, away, a pull, and home again.

I home · vi iii home's cousins · IV ii away · V the pull back home

The pop four
countless pop songs and ballads

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

The fifties
old rock 'n' roll and doo-wop

I C → vi Am → IV F → V G

The jazz three-step
jazz standards (as ii7, V7, Imaj7)

ii Dm → V G → I C

The canon
Pachelbel's Canon and its many children

I C → V G → vi Am → iii Em → IV F → I C → IV F → V G

1. Learn the trip by **numbers**: I V vi IV.
2. Pick a key and turn the numbers into chords: in C, **C G Am F**.
3. Play it round and round. Change key: the numbers stay the same.

Same trip, any key

The pop four	I	V	vi	IV
in C	C	G	Am	F
in G	G	D	Em	C
in F	F	C	Dm	B♭
in D	D	A	Bm	G

The twelve-bar blues

I C	I C	I C	I C
IV F	IV F	I C	I C
V G	IV F	I C	V G

The most famous trip of all is twelve bars long and uses only **I, IV and V**. Almost every blues, and a lot of rock 'n' roll, follows it. Play it in C with one chord per bar, four beats each.

Make it bluesy: turn every chord into a seventh (C7, F7, G7, p. 122).

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Play the pop four in A major

I ? → V ? → vi ? → IV ?

1. **Write the A major scale** (three sharps) and number the notes.
2. **Find notes 1, 5, 6 and 4.**
3. **Build each cake:** which one is minor?

A, E, F♯m, D: **the pop four in A.** Same trip, new key.

GAME

Name the trip

1 C · Am · F · G

2 Dm · G · C

3 C · G · Am · F

All in C major. Turn each into numbers, then name the trip: the pop four, the fifties or the jazz three-step.

Answer: 1 the fifties (I vi IV V) · 2 the jazz three-step (ii V I) · 3 the pop four (I V vi IV).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

Play C, G, Am, F, four beats each.

Go round four times without stopping. The left hand plays the chord's name note (C for C, A for Am), right hand the whole cake. Hum any tune you like over it.

TRAP

× Mixing up the pop four and the fifties: same four chords, different order. Listen to which chord comes second.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Cadences p. 139 · Chords under a melody p. 142

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 23–24 · Online: Library › Chords

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · TIPS

When the harmony goes wrong

Every chord can be right and the music still sound wrong: the ending will not close, or the left hand fights the tune. The slip is in how the chords move. Find which move it is, then fix that one.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
The end does not feel finished	**the cadence**: end with V → I	p. 139
A sharp or flat surprises you	**a guest**: sharps go up, flats go down, one key	p. 136
The left hand fights the tune	**the main notes**: pick the cake holding them	p. 142
A new song feels hard to learn	**the trip**: find I, IV, V and vi by number	p. 144

Four ways to hear the harmony

1 Hum the bass
Sing the lowest notes: they show where the chords move.

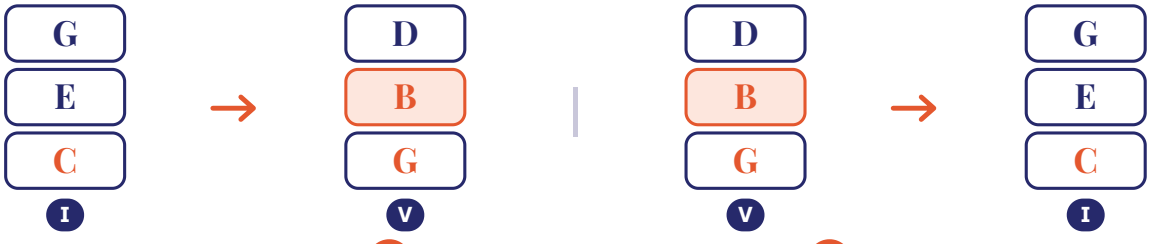
2 Tick the full stops
Mark every V → I in your piece with a red tick.

3 One trip, three keys
Play I–V–vi–IV in C, G and F: same numbers, new letters.

4 Chord a tune you know
Pick I, IV or V for each bar of Twinkle or Happy Birthday.

EXAMPLE

Fix the ending



1 The piece stops, but it does not feel finished. Look at the last two chords.

2 Name them: C then G is I → V. That is a comma, not a full stop.

3 Swap the order: G then C is V → I. The red B climbs one key to C, and the music lands.

A strong ending needs **V → I** (IV → I for a soft Amen): the last two chords are the full stop.

THINK OF IT Like a road trip: once you know where home is, every detour makes sense, and every road leads back to I.